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Bridging the Gap:

A Comparative Analysis of High School Educational Policies in the U.S. and Finland

The disparities in academic performance between the United States and Finland have become a subject of interest and concern among policymakers, educators, and researchers in recent years. According to the Programme for International Student Assessment, the results in 2018 showed the United States out of 79 countries ranked 47th in Math, 18th in science, and 13th in reading, which were below the OECD (Organization for Economic Co-operation and Development) average. In contrast, Finland was ranked 16th in Math, 6th in science, and 3rd in reading, which were way above the OECD average (Burg 2018). Despite both the United States and Finland having a highly developed education system, they are differentiated in their disciplinary policies that are influenced by their cultural nuances, which is reflected in the quality performance of students from these countries and the gap between them. Through a detailed comparative analysis of high school educational policies and governance structures in Finland and the United States, this study highlights how differences in disciplinary policies, driven by cultural nuances, contribute to significant disparities in academic performance. This paper will specifically explore how each country's approach to education, particularly in handling disciplinary measures and academic emphasis, correlates with their students' outcomes on international assessments and educational performances.

The Finnish education system, as described by Pasi Sahlberg, a Finnish education ambassador, offers a unique and effective approach to addressing educational equality. One of the pivotal components of this system is the implementation of school-based curricula that empower local educators to tailor educational experiences to meet the specific needs of their communities (Plesi 28). This decentralized approach fosters a sense of ownership and responsiveness among educators, allowing them to integrate local values and objectives into their teaching practices. The curricula developed at the school level are distinctly pragmatic, focusing on moral and educational values rather than adhering to politically driven national standards. As Sahlberg notes, these curricula often emphasize equity and equality, ensuring that every student has the opportunity to succeed, regardless of their background (Plesi 29). The Finnish system places a significant emphasis on professional development, recognizing the critical role of continuous learning for teachers and administrators. In Finland, educators are required to spend, on average, seven days per year in professional development activities, with a considerable portion of this time invested voluntarily (Plesi 29). This commitment to professional growth not only enhances the quality of education but also supports the implementation of the school-based curricula. By prioritizing professional development over standardized testing, Finland invests substantially in the capabilities of its educators, contrasting sharply with systems where the majority of resources are funneled into performance evaluations and tests (Plesi 29). Making its educators one of the contributing factors attributed to the success of education in Finland. Teachers are highly respected at the same levels as doctors. Being smart is not enough, as they must be deemed right with kids by having good personalities (Stade) emphasizing how not just anyone can become a teacher. A reform implemented in the late 1970s bolstered teacher training programs, elevating their standards significantly. This overhaul resulted in the integration of

teacher education into universities, requiring high school educators to hold a master's degree. Presently, teacher training is offered across nine universities, eight of which operate teacher training schools. Based on available data, only approximately 10% of applicants to teacher education programs are admitted. Prospective teacher candidates are required to have passed the Finnish matriculation examination (or its foreign equivalent) or completed a three-year vocational education program (OECD 2013).

In contrast and similarities, the educational landscape in the United States is characterized by a diverse array of policies and practices, each shaping the academic experiences of students in distinct ways. For example, the Fremont Unified School District, an American school, implements a comprehensive set of grading and testing policies aimed at fostering a balanced approach to student assessment (Fremont). Emphasizing the importance of manageable workloads, the district limits homework assignments in non-weighted classes to 100 minutes per week, with provisions for additional workload in advanced courses. The policy mandates regular grade updates and meaningful feedback to facilitate student learning and growth. Through these measures, the Fremont Unified School District demonstrates a commitment to academic excellence while prioritizing the holistic development and well-being of its students. American high schools often rely heavily on standardized testing as a means of evaluating student performance, which can lead to a narrow focus on test preparation rather than holistic learning experiences. While the Fremont Unified School District in the United States demonstrates a commitment to academic excellence through grading and testing policies, its approach differs from Finland's in terms of the emphasis on standardized assessments and centralized standards. Some American high schools face challenges related to family issues, socioeconomic disparities, and inadequate support systems. Students from disadvantaged backgrounds may struggle to cope

with academic demands due to external factors such as financial instability, lack of access to resources, or family responsibilities. Additionally, the pressure to perform well on standardized tests can exacerbate stress and anxiety among students, further hindering their academic progress.

In Finnish schools, discipline is not an issue because there is zero tolerance for misbehavior, and parents back this approach. The culture of respecting teachers means parents are less confrontational. With fewer disruptions, students focus better on learning. Because parents prioritize education, their children do too, leading to highly motivated and enthusiastic learners (Stade). Discipline in Finnish schools is crucial for students' academic performance. According to Carol Burg, discipline involves intentionally controlling habits to adhere to regulations and standards. It encompasses training acceptable behavior and unlearning maladaptive habits with guidance and direction. Effective discipline creates a predictable, orderly, and stress-free environment conducive to learning. Research has shown a positive link between discipline and academic performance, with Finland ranking as the 8th most educated nation globally. Finnish education emphasizes equity, with teachers focusing on high-quality basic education for all students regardless of background. Discipline in Finnish schools is not just about punishment but also about instilling values and morals, fostering self-control, and promoting positive relationships. Students are expected to respect school rules and regulations, with teachers having statutory authority to discipline students when necessary. Punishment, whether positive or negative, should be proportional and aimed at guiding students toward better behavior. Effective discipline lays the foundation for qualities like independence, punctuality, focus, motivation, and organization, which are valuable in society (Jarvinen 58). Research findings from correlation and regression analyses show a significant positive association between

discipline and student performance. Well-disciplined students serve as role models for their peers, contributing to a positive school environment.

American high schools often face disciplinary challenges stemming from various factors such as socioeconomic disparities, family issues, and a lack of support systems. Some American students may struggle to cope with the demands of school due to these external factors, leading to behavioral issues and academic underperformance (Galway 10). The disciplinary policies in American high schools may vary widely across districts and states, leading to inconsistencies in enforcement and outcomes. They typically rely on a combination of disciplinary measures, including rules and regulations, counseling services, peer mediation programs, and punitive actions such as detention or suspension. However, there is often a greater emphasis on punitive measures rather than proactive approaches aimed at addressing the root causes of student misbehavior. However, discipline should be cultivated from an early age and reinforced throughout the education process to ensure students develop into responsible individuals. Teachers, parents, and guardians play a crucial role in guiding and supervising students to prevent them from engaging in risky behaviors that could hinder their social and academic development. Overall, while Finnish schools prioritize creating a positive and supportive learning environment through proactive disciplinary measures and a cultural emphasis on respect, American high schools often grapple with disciplinary challenges and may rely more heavily on punitive measures to address student behavior.

To bridge the gap in academic performance between the United States and Finland, American high schools could adopt several strategies to enhance their policies and practices. Firstly, there is a need to shift the focus away from standardized testing as the primary means of evaluating student performance. Instead, schools should prioritize holistic learning experiences

that foster critical thinking, creativity, and problem-solving skills. By de-emphasizing standardized assessments and promoting a more well-rounded approach to education, American schools can better align with the principles of equity and inclusivity that underpin Finland's education system. Additionally, American high schools could invest more resources in professional development opportunities for educators, similar to Finland's model. By providing teachers with ongoing training and support, schools can enhance their capacity to tailor educational experiences to meet the diverse needs of students, ultimately improving academic outcomes and narrowing the performance gap.

In conclusion, the disparities in academic performance between the United States and Finland underscore the importance of examining and reevaluating educational policies and practices. While Finland's decentralized, holistic approach to education has yielded impressive results, American high schools face challenges related to standardized testing, disciplinary issues, and support systems. By learning from Finland's model and prioritizing student well-being, equity, and professional development, American schools can strive towards creating more inclusive, supportive, and effective learning environments. Ultimately, addressing these disparities requires a concerted effort from policymakers, educators, parents, and communities to ensure that all students have the opportunity to succeed and thrive in their educational journey.

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